INT. DUSTY COLLEGE APARTMENT — LIVING ROOM — NIGHT

Loud, slightly distorted music. The room is packed. The only light comes from a single string of cheap, colored Christmas lights draped haphazardly across a window. The air is thick with cheap beer and sweat.

VERONICA (20s, sharp, black cocktail dress with one strap delicately falling off her shoulder, both heels on, makeup flawless) leans against a kitchen counter, scrolling on her phone. JAKE (20s, athletic, neatly wrinkled button-up, collar loose, tie tucked in pocket, hair slightly tousled, red Solo cup in hand) stands a few feet away, watching her. His gaze is tight, calculating, like he knows better than everyone else around her.

MARK (22, tie-dye shirt, bouncing with excitement) notices Veronica and lights up like he’s found a kindred spirit.

MARK
(leaning in, voice bubbling with excitement)
Hey! Okay, this party is a solid C-minus, but you? You’re raising the curve. Seriously, what are you drinking? I need to get on your level.

Veronica glances up, smiling tightly. She holds up her cup.

VERONICA
Water. And it’s working wonders.

MARK
Water? No way! That’s… a power move. I respect it. You look like you’re having the most fun while being the most responsible person here. I… I don’t even know what to think.

He winks, overly dramatic. Veronica chuckles lightly, but immediately looks past him toward Jake. She’s done with the interaction.

Jake notices the wink, the laugh, the slight tilt of her head toward Mark. His jaw tightens, his stance rigid. He walks over slowly, hands in pockets, but his aura is subtly threatening.

MARK (cont’d)
…And then I told the professor that my essay on social hierarchies was basically revolutionary, and she—

Jake steps between them. His presence is calm, but there's an edge, a sense that he owns the space around her.

JAKE
(flat, smooth)
We were just about to head out.

Mark freezes, still grinning but slightly intimidated.

MARK
Oh. Uh… hey, man. Didn't see you there. Just… chatting with Veronica about Handover. You guys leaving?

Jake leans toward Veronica, voice low, almost patronizing.

JAKE
Yeah. We're going.

He places a hand lightly on her lower back, not guiding — asserting. Veronica stiffens, annoyed.

VERONICA
(irritated)
What are you doing?

JAKE
(voice calm but condescending)
Just making sure you're not… letting someone waste your time. You know how men are.

Veronica's eyes narrow.

VERONICA
(low, sharp)
Excuse me?

JAKE
(leaning slightly closer)
You think everyone's harmless, but they don't think like us. I'm just… protecting you.

MARK
(grinning nervously)
Yeah… okay… good luck with… whatever you guys have going.

Mark slowly backs away, hands raised, thrilled just to have had a conversation.

Jake starts moving Veronica toward the exit, still calm, still slightly patronizing, his eyes scanning the room.

JAKE
(soft, but insistent)
C'mon. Let's get out of here before anyone else gets any ideas.

Veronica exhales sharply, rolling her eyes, anger rising.

VERONICA
(low, tense)
You know, sometimes I can't deal with you at all.

JAKE
(voice teasing, slightly smug)
Deal with me or don't. I know better than anyone what's safe for you.

Veronica snaps, pushing past him toward the stairwell.

VERONICA
Enough, Jake! I'm not some girl you have to "protect" from the world!

Jake pauses, a flicker of guilt, but doesn't step in — his ego tells him he's in the right.

VERONICA (cont'd)
(fuming, muttering)
I just… I can't even.

She storms off down the hall, fists clenched, jaw tight — leaving Jake standing with a hand at his side, tense but convinced he's done the right thing.

INT. FRONT DOOR - LATER

A static shot. The front door stands still. The hum of night outside leaks in faintly.

VERONICA (20s), flushed and breathing heavily, storms in. Her mascara is streaked from sweat or tears, a strap of her black cocktail dress falling off one shoulder. One heel dangles from her hand, the other still on. Her lipstick is worn down from anxious biting. She brushes past the camera without a word, jaw tight, eyes wet with restrained tears.

Moments later, JAKE (20s) enters. His button-up is wrinkled, the collar loose, one side of his shirt half-untucked.

His tie is shoved into a pocket, hair tousled from running his hands through it. He shuts the door slowly — more careful. His jaw is clenched, shoulders tense, eyes locked in the direction she went.

INT. KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

Jake follows her in. Veronica throws her purse onto the counter with a harsh thud. Her body is stiff, pacing.

JAKE
You didn't even say goodbye to me.

VERONICA
Because you were embarrassing me. Again.

Jake steps forward, voice rising, arms slightly out in disbelief.

JAKE
That's not fair. I was looking out for you.

VERONICA
(blurting out)
No!

She clenches her fists, then takes a breath, lowering her voice but not her anger.

VERONICA (cont'd)
You were trying to control me.

Jake stands there, frozen. His face softens. Veronica turns sharply and exits.

INT. HALLWAY TO BEDROOM — NIGHT

Veronica storms down the hallway, wiping tears from her face. Her footsteps echo as she slams the bedroom door and locks it.

VERONICA (O.S.)
I HATE YOU!

Jake reaches the door, tries the handle.

JAKE
Why even say that?
(beat)
We both know it's not true.

INT. BEDROOM — INSIDE, AT THE DOOR — CONTINUOUS

Veronica sits on the floor with her back to the door. She curls into herself, fingers trembling, wiping at her cheeks.

VERONICA
They’re my friends! You never trust me!

INT. HALLWAY — OUTSIDE BEDROOM DOOR — CONTINUOUS

Jake leans his forehead against the door. His voice drops.

JAKE
(softly)
Oh no, baby… don’t cry.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(sharp, through tears)
Fuck you! Go away. Leave me alone.

JAKE
Okay, my love.

He scratches his neck, trying to stay calm.

JAKE (cont’d)
I’ll be in the kitchen making dinner.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(muffled, bitter)
I’m not hungry.

JAKE
You say that now. But I know you’ll eat.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(beat, dry laugh through anger)
You don’t “know” everything, Jake. That’s the problem.

JAKE
Maybe. But I know I can’t walk away from this door while you’re crying on the other side.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(quiet, defensive)
Then stop being the reason I fucking cry.

JAKE
Veronica?

VERONICA (O.S.)
(startled, voice still raw)
Yeah? What?

JAKE
You know I love you, right… baby?

A long silence. Jake closes his eyes, guilt settling in.

JAKE (cont'd)
I know I screw up. I overthink. I get paranoid. But that doesn't mean I don't love you. That's the one thing I don't doubt.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(quiet, sharp)
Then prove it. Stop accusing me. Stop turning every smile I give someone else into a crime.

JAKE
(beat)
You're right. I'm sorry.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(flat)
Words are easy, Jake.

Jake sinks down, sitting against the door, fiddling with his tie. His voice is lower, stripped of bravado.

JAKE
Then I'll show you. I'll cook. I'll wait. I'll be here until you're ready.

A pause. On the other side, Veronica exhales shakily.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(soft, reluctant)
You're really stubborn, you know that?

JAKE
Takes one to know one.

There's the faintest laugh from inside. Not forgiveness, just a crack in the wall.

VERONICA (O.S.)
Don’t push it.

JAKE
(smug, defensive)
Wouldn’t dream of it. You’ll just find a way to twist it on me anyway.

Jake smirks at the floor, waiting for her to answer.

JAKE (cont’d)
(beat, louder)
You know I wouldn’t be on this side of the door if I didn’t love you. Most guys would’ve just left by now.

INT. BEDROOM — INSIDE, AT THE DOOR — CONTINUOUS

Veronica presses her fingers together, eyes rolling even as her voice softens.

VERONICA
(sniffles)
Yeah, yeah, I know you do… I love you too. But seriously — you have to stop accusing me of cheating all the time. That guy was just my friend.

JAKE (O.S.)
I’m not saying he isn’t. I’m saying I’ve seen what happens. I don’t want anything to happen to you, and I’m the only one looking out for you.

VERONICA
(teasing, voice softening)
Aw, is that why you’ve been so overprotective? You’re worried something’s gonna happen to lil’ old me?

JAKE (O.S.)
You know I overthink. But I don’t overthink my love for you. That part’s always been true. Even with this door between us — I couldn’t walk away knowing you were hurting on the other side.

VERONICA
You wouldn’t have to overthink if you just listened to me.
(MORE)

VERONICA (cont'd)
How many times are you gonna offer me space then just camp there on the other side of this door?

JAKE
Because I can't. You don't get to just shut me out. I'm not walking away, not while you're in pain. Not ever.

VERONICA (O.S.)
And what? You want me to start listing all the ways you drive me crazy?
(beat)
You're stubborn, cocky, way too handsome for your own good… and a controlling little shit. Happy now?

JAKE
(smirk, leaning closer to the door)
Exactly how I like it. I'm yours, whether you like it or not.

VERONICA (O.S.)
No. Stop saying that like it's romantic. You're not mine and I'm not yours. That's not how this works, Jake. Quit acting like you own me. It's giving me a headache.

JAKE
Giving you a headache? You should see the way I overthink it all. My brain just loops the same concerns.

VERONICA (O.S.)
And that's your problem to fix, not mine. I'm not your punching bag for paranoia. You know my grandmother once told me, "Men who seem to wear their heart on their seams, seem to be the ones who scheme." Right now? Great fucking advice! Maybe take it! Because constantly reminding me you're "loyal" doesn't make you trustworthy, Jake. It makes you look insecure.

JAKE
Sure, some guys scheme. But don't confuse me with them. The difference is, I don't play games.
(MORE)

JAKE (cont'd)
I'm the one actually loyal here, and somehow I'm the guy being questioned? You know good guys like me still exist, right?

VERONICA (O.S.)
Loyalty isn't about you bragging every five minutes. It's about trust. And right now, you don't have mine.

JAKE
(half-laughs, defensive)
Oh yeah? When do I get to meet the guy who does?

VERONICA (O.S.)
(snaps)
Cut it out. That jealous routine isn't cute anymore. Either trust me, or don't — but stop accusing me. I'm done babying your ego.

JAKE
(backs off a little)
…Fine.

VERONICA (O.S.)
Good. Now maybe try listening instead of joking.

JAKE
(dryly)
That's new territory for me.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(with a faint laugh, still firm)
Yeah, it is. But you'd better start learning.

VERONICA (O.S.) (cont'd)
I can just picture you out there, all cocky and standing like you own the place.

JAKE
(puts his finger up, smirking)
Erm… actually, I'm sitting.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(laughs)
Sitting, not standing. My mistake, Mr. Smartypants. Anything else you want to correct me on?

JAKE
No.

VERONICA (O.S.)
You're quite the strategic smartass, aren't you? Knowing exactly when to quit and when to keep going. That must be why I still love you.

JAKE
I wish I had a reason to love me.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(sharp)
Stop. Don't drag me into your pity party. You can be dramatic all you want, but don't expect me to fix your self-esteem. Handle it yourself.

JAKE
I know. I was being melodramatic.

VERONICA (O.S.)
Good. Keep it that way. No self-pity — that's not going to get you any points here.

JAKE
I know.

(Jake stands up.)

JAKE (cont'd)
I'm gonna work on dinner.

VERONICA (O.S.)
Go ahead. Just… don't ruin it with more drama while you cook.

JAKE
I never stop loving you.

VERONICA (O.S.)
I know. And I don't stop either — but love isn't an excuse to act like a jerk.

JAKE
So, same time tomorrow?

VERONICA (O.S.)
(half-smirk)
If you survive today without more accusations, maybe.

JAKE
Way cheaper than therapy. And the payoff afterwards isn't bad either.

VERONICA (O.S.)
(laughs, teasing)
Yeah, well, make sure your cooking is as good as your charm — or no forgiveness for you.

JAKE
Noted. I'm making your favorite. You won't resist the first bite.

VERONICA (O.S.)
We'll see about that. Just remember, you don't deserve my forgiveness.